

Two good links, one edge each

In Step and Short Run, against each other and against today's link

What both share

Fourteen designs are in the pack; these two balance best what weighs most here. Everything below holds for both, each line better than or level with today; what they share that is worse than today is on page 2.

- ✓ All **9 of 9** December staffing rules (today 4), and all three flexible ones: 14 on a Saturday, evenly spaced cover weeks, 15:45 weekday closers
- ✓ **7 full weekends off in 26**, never more than 5 weeks apart (today 4 in 20, up to 7 apart)
- ✓ Every closing shift **shorter, by 30 minutes to an hour** — the weekday's and Sunday's 8h 10m on both (today 8h 40m and 8h 55m); no shift over 9h 00m
- ✓ **4 single rest days** in the rotation, as today — about 8 a year each, today 10; rest days otherwise in pairs or longer (22 of 26 breaks, today 13 of 17)
- ✓ **No avoidable fatigue warning**; never more than **five days in a row** on the fixed rota, six if a cover week falls badly (today 4 warnings, up to 5; seven days, up to nine)
- ✓ The same **35-hour** week and **218.6 days** a year, under the ceiling of 219 (today 219.0)
- ✓ **One shift time Monday to Friday in 18 of 21 weeks**, and no week mixing earlies and lates (today 7 of 16, with 7 mixing)
- ✓ The same **1h 13m week-to-week change** of start time (today 4h 00m), and the same Sunday

Where they differ

the better of the two on each line in bold green; today for scale, not ranked

MEASURE	TODAY	IN STEP	SHORT RUN
Heaviest week, Mon–Sat	43h 50m	**41h 05m**	42h 30m
Lightest week, Mon–Sat	25h 10m	**25h 30m**	24h 30m
Shortest rest, fixed duties	12h 30m	**14h 35m**	14h 20m
Closing shift, Saturday	9h 10m	**8h 10m**	8h 40m
Earlies over 8h 30m, each a year	0	42	**22**
Any shift over 8h 30m, each a year	39	42	**28**
Earlies finishing before 14:00, each a year	26	**12**	0
New shift times on a Saturday	0	1	**0**
Fit to the trains, weekday · Sat (0 = exact; Sunday 29.0 on both, today 71.7)	52.0 · 65.9	29.8 · **9.6**	**29.1** · 12.7

Each one's edge

In Step

IS-26-T4 · 8d9239f3

The shorter closers and the more even weeks. Every closer Monday to Saturday 8h 10m (Short Run's Saturday one 8h 40m), no Mon–Sat week over 41h 05m (Short Run 42h 30m), 14h 35m the shortest rest, a Saturday fit of 9.6 against 12.7, and today's 13:45 kept every weekday. Its cost is the earlies — 42 a year each over 8h 30m (Short Run 22) — with a weekday fit a shade behind (29.8 against 29.1) and a new time on a Saturday, its closer.

Short Run

SR-26-F1 · 618348d6

Fewer long days. 28 shifts a year each over 8h 30m, fewer than today's 39 and In Step's 42; the closer fit to the weekday trains (29.1 against 29.8); and nothing new on a Saturday: all six of its times there are worked today, three of them on a Saturday. Its cost: an 8h 40m Saturday closer, a 42h 30m heaviest Mon–Sat week, 14h 20m the shortest rest, a Saturday fit of 12.7, and no early finish before 14:00 (today 26 a year each).

Which one, by what matters most

IF THE MAIN PRIORITY IS	CHOOSE
Of these two, the shorter closers and more even weeks, with today's 13:45 kept	**In Step**
Of these two, fewer long days, the closer weekday fit, and nothing new on a Saturday	**Short Run**
The fewest long days of all: no early over 8h 30m	**Home Grown** · outside the shortlist
The shortest closers of all: 16:00 Monday to Saturday	**Closing Time** · outside the shortlist, as is Both Ways
A fourth person to the Saturday close	**Even Keel** · outside the shortlist, as are Fine Tune and Second Gear
The steadiest start times from week to week	**Second Edition** · outside the shortlist
Four weeks off for 14 days' leave, as today	**Long Break** · outside the shortlist

THE SHORTLIST · CONTINUED

Against today, and a recommendation

On most of what a colleague feels the two are the same — a figure in grey is shared by both

Against today's link

MEASURE	TODAY	IN STEP	SHORT RUN
Full weekends off, about a year	10	14	14
Saturdays a year, each	26	28	28
Sunday overtime duties a year, each	21	20	20
Starting at 06:20, each a year	62	60	60
Average shift, Monday to Saturday	8h 14m	8h 16m	8h 16m
Longest shift	9h 10m	9h 00m	9h 00m
14 days' leave buys, at best	30 days off	28 days off	28 days off
14 days' leave buys, at worst	19 days off	20 days off	20 days off
Leave for four full weeks off	14 days	15 days	15 days

Per year: the rotation's count scaled to 52 weeks; days a year, Monday to Saturday with a cover week as four, over 365 days.

Why these two and not the other twelve

These two balance best what weighs most here — days in a row, weekends, one shift time a week, late finishes and the closing shift. Each of the others keeps something neither has, and pays for it. Closing Time and Both Ways have shorter closers and fewer shift times to learn — Closing Time also more even weeks, a gentler step, the best Saturday fit and 2 long earlies a year, Both Ways a lighter heaviest week and more early finishes — for a weaker weekday fit and fewer weeks on one turn, with more finishes at 22:00 or later on Closing Time and more long shifts on Both Ways. Home Grown has the fewest long days of all and the fewest new times, two, with a shorter weekday closer, for today's 9h 10m Saturday closer, fewer weeks on one turn and a weaker fit. Even Keel, Fine Tune and Second Gear have fewer long days and a fourth person to the Saturday close (Fine Tune a gentler step too), for more late finishes, weeks mixing earlies and lates, longer blocks of earlies or lates and a weaker Saturday fit, and on Fine Tune and Second Gear fewer weeks on one turn. Second Edition has the gentlest step, for six days in a row. Long Break gives four weeks off for 14 days' leave and a 29-day best stretch, for six days in a row, a fifth single rest day, fewer weeks on one turn and a 1h 44m step. Second Look, Second Nature, Second Sight and Second Wind have blocks of earlies or lates a week shorter (Second Look fewer shift times too), for six days in a row, fewer weeks on one turn and a bigger step — and on Second Nature, weekends up to ten weeks apart.

The honest costs, shared by both

- **Late finishes.** 42 a year each at 23:00 or later (today 39) and 94 at 22:00 or later (today 78) on both. Three to the close every day, where today has two Monday to Saturday, means no link meeting the rules has fewer than 42 at 23:00 or later.
- **Long days.** Earlies over 8h 30m, where today has none — 42 a year each on In Step, 22 on Short Run — and fewer early finishes before 14:00 (12 and none; today 26).
- **Leave.** The best 14-day stretch is 28 days off, not today's 30; four full weeks off, Sunday to Saturday, takes 15 days' leave, not 14. The worst stretch is a day better. Both are worse than today here, on something people plan a year around; Long Break alone keeps the 14.
- **Saturdays.** About 2 more a year (28, today 26): fourteen on a Saturday, the flexible rule, across 26 lines (today ten across 20).
- **New times.** 6 of 15 shift times are new on both (9 are worked today). On Short Run four of the new ones are shorter versions of today's lates and one a longer weekday early; on In Step three, and two longer weekday earlies. Both add a 9-hour Sunday early, 09:00–18:00.

Recommendation

In Step. On what weighs most here it equals Short Run — days in a row, weekends, weeks on one shift time and late finishes, and the leave too — and is ahead on the closing shift: every closer Monday to Saturday 8h 10m, where Short Run's Saturday one is 8h 40m. It also has more even weeks, Monday to Saturday (25h 30m to 41h 05m against 24h 30m to 42h 30m), the longer shortest rest (14h 35m against 14h 20m), the better Saturday fit (9.6 against 12.7) and today's 13:45 kept every weekday. Its cost is long days: 42 earlies a year each over 8h 30m against Short Run's 22 — In Step's mostly 8h 45m and 8h 55m, Short Run's all 9h 00m — so 42 shifts over 8h 30m against 28, with a new time on a Saturday and a weekday fit a shade behind (29.8 against 29.1). Counting each day of a week once, the two fit the trains alike (26.8 and 26.7).

But it is close. On the pack's weighted league (the owner's weights, a judgement) In Step is first of the fourteen and Short Run fourth, two points behind (88.4 against 86.4). The league scores neither the closing shift nor long earlies, and In Step has the most long earlies of any design here: counted as heavily as the league counts late finishes, they would put Short Run ahead of In Step; any lighter than it counts single rest days, and In Step stays ahead of it. So choose by what matters here:

- **Choose In Step** if the closing shift and more even weekly hours matter most, and colleagues value today's 13:45.
- **Choose Short Run** if long days matter more: 22 long earlies a year each instead of 42, the closer weekday fit and nothing new on a Saturday — for an 8h 40m Saturday closer and a 42h 30m Mon–Sat week.